Thy Word Is a Lamp

God's word is to be loved, pondered and obeyed; it gives wisdom for life and light for each step of the way.

Main passage	Psalm 119:97-105 (KJV)
Topic	Word of God
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Love God's word and keep it near	7 min
Teaching point 2: God's word gives wisdom for life	7 min
Teaching point 3: A lamp for each step	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What book, other than the Bible, has influenced you most? Why?" Then ask: "What would you say to someone who asked why you read the Bible?" Today we listen to a psalm-writer who could not stop talking about how much he loved God's word.

Scripture (3 min)

Psalm 119:97-105

97 O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day. 98 Thou through thy commandments hast made me wiser than mine enemies: for they are ever with me. 99 I have more understanding than all my teachers: for thy testimonies are my meditation. 100 I understand more than the ancients, because I keep thy precepts. 101 I have refrained my feet from every evil way, that I might keep thy word. 102 I have not departed from thy judgments: for thou hast taught me. 103 How sweet are thy words unto my taste! yea, sweeter than honey to

my mouth! [104] Through thy precepts I get understanding: therefore I hate every false way. [105] Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to listen for the different words used for God's word: law, commandments, testimonies, precepts, word.

Background (5 min)

Psalm 119 is the longest chapter in the Bible: 176 verses in 22 sections of 8 verses, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet. In the original, every verse in a section begins with the same letter. Almost every verse mentions God's word under one name or another.

Today's verses come from the section beginning with the letter Mem (vv. 97-104) and the first verse of the Nun section (v. 105). The writer is unnamed. Some have suggested David or Daniel, but the psalm itself does not say.

Teacher note: "Law" here (Hebrew torah) means more than rules. It means God's instruction, everything he has taught his people.

Teaching point 1: Love God's word and keep it near (7 min)

"O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day" (v. 97). The writer does not merely tolerate Scripture; he loves it, and that love shows in how often he thinks about it. Meditation means turning God's word over in the mind throughout the day, as a cow chews its cud.

Supporting verses

Psalm 119:97: O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day.

Psalm 1:1-2: Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful. But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.

Joshua 1:8: This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.

> *"This is one of the strongest marks of a gracious and pious heart, cast in the mould of obedience."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 119:97

Handout blanks (answers)

O how love I thy law! it is my **meditation** all the day.

Meditation means turning God's word over in the **mind** throughout the day.

Teaching point 2: God's word gives wisdom for life (7 min)

The writer says God's word has made him wiser than his enemies, his teachers and the elders (vv. 98-100). This is not pride; the wisdom is not his own. Real understanding of God, ourselves and life comes from God's word, and it grows as we obey it (vv. 101-104). To the one who loves it, it is "sweeter than honey."

Supporting verses

Psalm 119:98-104 (read from the Bible)

2 Timothy 3:15-17: And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus. All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works.

James 1:22-25: But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves. For if any be a hearer of the word, and not a doer, he is like unto a man beholding his natural face in a glass: For he beholdeth himself, and goeth his way, and straightway forgetteth what manner of man he was. But whoso looketh into the perfect law of liberty, and continueth therein, he being not a forgetful hearer, but a doer of the work, this man shall be blessed in his deed.

> *"Spiritual knowledge increases while we tread in the path of obedience. Obedience is the grand means of growth and instruction."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 119:104

> *"There is such a thing as a spiritual taste"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 119:103-104

Handout blanks (answers)

Through thy precepts I get **understanding**.

Spiritual knowledge grows as we **obey** God's word.

Teaching point 3: A lamp for each step (7 min)

"Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path" (v. 105). In the ancient world a small oil lamp lit only a few steps ahead. God's word does not always show us the whole road at once, but it gives enough light for the next step, and then the next.

Supporting verses

Psalm 119:105: Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.

Proverbs 6:23: For the commandment is a lamp; and the law is light; and reproofs of instruction are the way of life:

2 Peter 1:19: We have also a more sure word of prophecy; whereunto ye do well that ye take heed, as unto a light that shineth in a dark place, until the day dawn, and the day star arise in your hearts:

> *"Not only does the Word of God inform us of His will, but, as a light on a path in darkness, it shows us how to follow the right and avoid the wrong way."*
>
> — Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 119:105

Handout blanks (answers)

Thy word is a **lamp** unto my feet.

God's word gives enough light for the **next** step.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. What is the difference between reading the Bible and meditating on it?

Reading takes in the words; meditating lingers, reflects, applies and prays them through the day.

2. The writer says Scripture made him wiser than his teachers. In what ways can God's word give wisdom that education alone cannot?

It reveals God, our hearts, right and wrong, and the purpose of life; it gives wisdom for living, not just information.

3. Why do you think the writer links obedience with understanding (vv. 100-104)?

We learn God's word most deeply by doing it; disobedience dulls understanding.

4. When has God's word been a "lamp" for a next step in your life?

Answers will vary.

Application (3 min)

Choose one verse from today's passage. Write it on a card, and read it at breakfast, lunch and bedtime every day this week. Also set a regular daily time and place to read Scripture, even if it is just one chapter.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, thank you for your word, a lamp to our feet and a light to our path. Give us a love for it like the psalmist's. Help us meditate on it through the day, obey it, and find it sweeter than honey. Light our next step, and lead us in your way. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 119:97

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Psalm 119:104

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Psalm 119:103-104

Andrew Robert Fausset, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on Psalm 119:105

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